You Weren't Even Supposed to be Home

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
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Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Scorpia's Mom (Garnet)/Ma (Linda)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Scorpia's Mothers (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
SPOP Creative Flex (She-Ra), SPOP Flex Secret Solstice (She-Ra), Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - College/University, Fluff, Fluff and Humor, Slice of Life, Nonbinary Adora (She-Ra), Jock Adora (She-Ra), Nerdy Catra, video games - Freeform, Winter Break, mention of sports, I know nothing about sports, Past Estrangement, New Years, New Year's Eve, New Year's Traditions at Midnight, you know the one I mean, Gaming Together is Romantic, Dorks in Love, But They Don't Realize It Yet, Alternate Universe - Roommates/Housemates

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by MxSinshine

Summary

Winter break, finally. All her roommates will be of the apartment too, leaving Catra more than ready for weeks of nothing but video games and sweet, sweet naps.

Of course, Scorpia didn't mean to put Adora on the sidelines right before semester end, but now that their arm is in a sling, guess who's not going to be so alone in the apartment over winter break...

Ready Player One, Here Comes Player Two.

For RomanValkyrie, as part of the SPOP Creative Flex Secret Solstice Exchange.

Notes

Hi everyone, it's ya they here, back with another Secret Solstice fic. Woo!For those of you who may not be familiar , over the summer an event called the SPOPCreativeFlex was created. Some members of the Flex wanted to do an end of the year gift exchange, the Secret Solstice. This fic is written for RomanValkyrie as part of that exchange.

Roman!Heard you like video games;hey , me too!There's so much more I could have stuck in here- references, jokes, games for the two of them to play... But this thing grew and grew quick! So much that I went ahead and split it into two chapters. I'll have

the second chapter posted by Friday at the latest. I certainly hope that you had a wonderful holiday season, Roman, and that this þck enby Adora and nerdy Catra fic makes you smile. A very happy new year to you!

Finally readers, I don't tend to do this (mostly because I write fluff lol), but a qick CW for misgendering seems warranted. The scene is incredibly brief and is qickly resolved- because Adora has a strong sense of self and Catra delightfully protective of her dummy. Happens pretty close to the end and I promise you, it's þst a couple lines.

Catch you later on in the week with the wrap up for this one!

Chapter 1

"Oh my gosh, oh my gosh!" With a bang, the front door to their apartment flew open and suddenly all *three* of Catra's roommates filed in at the same time. Scorpia led the stampede, walking backwards. Her voice was a few octaves higher than normal as she gestured wildly towards the next in line, Adora. "I still can't believe this. I am *so, so* sorry!"

"It's okay, Scorp. Really. These things happen and it was a good play."

At the sound of their voice, Catra's head turned instinctively, entirely forgetting to pause her game. She had holed up in the living room, taking advantage of Sparkles' massive TV, but there while the three other hooligans she resided with were off at practice. Pretty normal Saturday afternoon stuff. But they were back way too early and the reason was evident: Adora's arm was in a sling.

"Let me get you some ice!"

The large woman nearly fell over herself in her haste to get to the refrigerator, dangerously close to adding to the list of injuries for the day. Sparkles was in the rear, toting not only her own gym bag, but two others too, and looking none too pleased by being elected the group's packhorse. The bags were tossed into the corner by their shoe rack, which was Catra's *favorite* thing obviously- who didn't want to enter a home and be immediately assaulted by the scent of sweaty gear, while Adora plopped down into their recliner, wincing slightly as the zealous movement jarred their shoulder.

"What the hell happened?" Catra demanded, eyebrows furrowing together at the clamor that had interrupted what had been a pretty damn great, quiet day up until now.

"Practice," Adora waved off the question, kicking off their tennis shoes somewhere towards the middle of the living room floor. Catra had grudgingly accepted long ago that they were never going to end up anywhere near the door with the rest of the shoes, on the rack, where they *belonged,* and only hid the damn things throughout the apartment on very special occasions . Separately, of course. Adora loved the challenge of finding their shoes almost as much as Catra loved the clutter. "We were running a new formation and Scorpia got me between the wall."

"Wait, you're saying your shoulder got busted from friendly fire?" Catra couldn't help the laugh, though at Scorpia's puppy dog eyes and obvious remorse, she at least tried to smother the worst of her snickers. "You checked your own player?"

"It's not busted." Adora asserted, gladly taking the offered ice pack from their teammate and shoving it up under the sling. The sigh of relief was immediate. "Only a little banged up and it's *temporary.* I'm just out for the next week or two, no big."

"Uh, you mean the rest of the semester? Both games? It's already after Thanksgiving, dummy."

"Oh, so you *do* pay attention to the game day shared calendar!" Glimmer said faux-cheerfully, settling onto what was unequivocally her sofa. Pale pink and absolutely covered with throw pillows. Catra hated the eyesore, especially since it was the perfect place to nap. "But not the date. Last actual season game this semester was Thursday night against the Fractal Flakes. We crushed it by the way, not that you've ever bothered to come support us. The only thing left in the year is the annual charity game, right at the end of finals week. We'll pick back up after break, of course."

"And Adora's going to miss it! Tradition, all ruined because of me." Scorpia hung her head, bottom lip blubbering out. "I should sit out that night too."

"So we can be down two of our best players?" Glimmer snorted. "I don't think so. It might be for charity, but I still want to win. Besides, punishing yourself doesn't fix Adora's shoulder. They'll be fine, right, boo?"

"Of course!" Adora quickly agreed. "I'll still be on the bench that night, cheering you all on. It's one game, Scorp, and it's against the Crimson Flames. Charitable donation or not, I almost feel bad that people are gonna pay to attend because it's not going to be much of a match. Why does a university out in the *desert* even have a hockey team?" They flashed a knowing grin at both their teammates, obviously impressed with their quip.

"Yeah because having one right here in balmy Brightmoon makes so much more sense." Catra murmured with an eye roll. She stood up from the comfortable nest she had built for herself, pulling her Switch from the dock. As she passed out of the living room on her way to finish gaming in her bed, Catra gave a half-glance towards Adora, "Glad you're not like completely fucked up or whatever."

"All good. I'll be back on the ice in no time. Coach is just being..." A knowing chuckle paired with a quick roll of their eyes upwards followed. "Eh, sure you remember how it is; can't be too careful with injuries! She just wants me to rest it for a few days."

Catra absently nodded before retreating. She did remember.

The days leading up to winter break had the courtesy to pass by quickly. Catra was pleased; for the most part she didn't have finals, only papers to write, most of which she'd spent the semester preparing and researching for already. Sure it meant that she spent a little more time in the library, but it was so worth it to be ahead of the game. While everyone else had spent the week cramming and panicking, she was currently tucked up in her comfy clothes, picking

at a game of Civilization. Not one in her normal rotation, but it felt right to play tonight. Build a nation, crush her enemies, or win them over in diplomacy. She was certain she'd make a kickass leader , if ever given the chance to run a horde.

At ten minutes to 5, Glimmer and Scorpia came trotting out of their respective rooms, dressed in all but their skates. The bulky shoulder pads looked even more ridiculous in the middle of their living room. Catra flicked an eye their way before refocusing on her conquest. If she built here, she'd have a waterfront, but the floodplain could cause problems later-…

"Let' s go Brightmoon, let's go!" Adora came scurrying out of their room and suddenly Sparkles and Scorp weren't even remotely the most ridiculously dressed. They were decked from head to toe in gear to support the Brightmoon Royals, their white home jersey draping over their frame, too big for them without the protective pads Adora normally wore with it. A truly absurd, overly large foam crown was perched on their head and a rainbow mane hung from the back of it as an homage to the unicorn mascot of the team (Catra never understood what a stupid winged horse had to do with royalty, but she supposed it was better than some stodgy, white bearded aristocrat they could have chosen to represent the Royals). They were in garish gold leggings and Adora had found a bright purple *cape* of all things to really tie in the look, such as it was. Their arm was still in a sling, but with their good hand they held a pennant with the Royals Crest on it, excitedly flapping it around as they cheered.

Catra blinked at the display and bit the inside of her cheek as hard as she could, but that didn't stop her raucous laughter . "Oh holy hell, it's like school spirit threw up all over you. Gonna ride around on Swiftie during the half-time show dressed like that?"

Adora stuck out their tongue, but the crown slipped over their eyes at that point, the blonde dummy struggling to push it back up with only one functional arm. It only made Catra laugh harder.

"Pf ff, that creepy girl-K would be *way* too into that." Glimmer remarked, referring to the person inside the mascot costume with a small shudder. She turned to the decked out enby in her living room. "I think they look cute! And at least Adora' s trying to have some fun. Enjoy your pixels or whatever , while we're out with *real people* ."

Catra rolled her eyes at the played out jab, exaggerating a yawn. Sparkles really needed to get some fresh new material for the spring semester. As long as she'd known the woman, which was truly longer than Catra would like, Glimmer was always on her case about being a "shut in." It suited Catra just fine; she had a small group of people she actually liked and the rest could fuck off.

"But c'mon, Coach wants us on the ice in twenty for warm ups." The short woman hoisted up her gym bag and trudged to the door, Scorpia babbling happily behind her, thrilled to be headed off to the charity game.

Adora once again had to adjust their crown as it dipped down to obscure their vision, the corner of Catra's mouth ticking up at the repeated sight. Their eyes locked briefly before Catra turned back to her game, nonplussed by the thought of not spending her Friday night anywhere near screeching fans, loud buzzers, and stale chips with funky nacho "cheese." Maybe she'd switch games in a bit, scrounge up some form of food-...

"Hey , uh, I know you're busy right now ," Adora' s eyes flicked to the large screen idly looking over the peninsula Catra was about to settle on. "T aking over the world and all, but you know you could join us. If you wanted."

"Y. eah." Catra replied softly . She hadn't been back to the rink since freshman year. Scorpia had convinced her to come to one game back then and while it was fine, a small part of Catra twinged to not be on the ice too. She had played with, and against, a number of the players skating about; the benefits of attending a pretty local university. But that was her decision and she was sticking with it. "I know. Just go have fun, dummy. I'm fine right here."

Adora bit their bottom lip, looking like they had more they wanted to say, but thankfully, refrained. "Okay , Catra. Have fun. We might go out for a bite after the game;I could text you?"

"Nothing' s stopping you." Right before Adora closed the door Catra called out, "Y ou damn well better if you go to Big Mama's!"

Adora flashed a grin and nodded, readjusting their crown one last time and waving their stupid pennant Catra's way as a sort of goodbye. Catra rolled her eyes at the gesture, but smiled as she finally built the damn city.

There was nothing quite as refreshing as waking up on the first Saturday of break, knowing that weeks of nothing but whatever Catra wanted to do lay ahead of her. It had to already be late morning;Scorpia had popped into her room briefly to shout-whisper a goodbye before she hit the road to head home to see her moms, only asking twice if Catra was sure about staying home. She was. She might go to Linda and Garnet's for the actual Solstice, maybe, but those two had already put up with Catra enough for a lifetime. Let them spend time with their actual daughter.

Besides, Catra was looking forward to having the apartment all to herself and the time to really wind down and recharge before classes started up again. She'd heard Sparkles talk about spending her break at some bougie-ass ski chalet with her family and Arrow Boy, and inevitably stories of that dumb trip would be all Catra would hear from Glimmer and Adora once they got back from break. Yay.

After a big, long stretch across the length of her bed, Catra finally rose for the day. She padded out towards the fridge, intent on stuffing what was left of her Big Mama burrito in her face for breakfast. Maybe she hadn't felt like meeting anyone out last night, but it was pretty cool of Adora to at least bring her back something. Crud, had she Venmo'd them for that-...

"Cute boxers."

Catra startled at the voice, nearly dropping her tinfoil wrapped pound of delightful Mexican leftovers right on the kitchen floor. She quickly glanced down at her current outfit, unable to recall just what the fuck she'd thrown on before collapsing into bed last night. The black A-line tank was fine, but the bright teal boxer briefs with little monkeys and bananas all over them? *Shit* . They were a white elephant gift from who knew how long ago and an entry in Catra's "I really need to do laundry" sleepwear . She hated them, but they were incredibly comfortable and fit annoyingly well. Not that she had expected anyone to see how great they made her ass look because they were still covered in *monkeys and bananas* .

Aware that she had been dumbly staring at herself for several long seconds now, Catra's head snapped up and her eyes widened as she caught sight of Adora. They were spread out across Sparkles' couch, obviously just scrolling aimlessly on their phone before Catra had emerged from her den. With a gulp to gather herself, Catra spat out, "What the fuck are you doing here?"

"Did I forget to pay rent this month? Huh. T ake the cost of that burrito you're scarfing down out of it, I guess, and Ill toss it your way ." Adora lazed with an easy grin. "Pretty sure I live here, Cat."

"W ell, duh, dumbass. But it's break?"

"Uhuh." Adora drawled, raising their eyebrow .

When no follow up came, Catra exclaimed, "Why arent you of f with Sparkles at that ridiculous resort or whatever the fuck she's been babbling about for weeks!" She was positive during the goodbyes/check in from Scorpia this morning that she'd heard the dulcet tones of Glimmer whining about being up so early so they could leave for their dumb trip. If Catra really took a minute to think about it, she didn't necessarily hear Adora during the hissyfit, but she had also quickly stuf fed earplugs in her ears and told Scorpia to have a nice break, but let her fucking sleep already.

Adora sat up, their long legs stretching out before them as they entered a new position to lounge in. Catra twitched;they really needed to turn down the heat in the apartment if both of them were hanging around in shorts. Adora's barely covered their thighs…

"W ell, for one, this."They gestured towards their shoulder still hung up in a sling. "Doesnt exactly make for easy skiing. But I wasnt ever planning on joining the Moons for Solstice this year ."

"Y ou coulda told me that."Catra grumbled, finally tearing her eyes away and returning to heating up her burrito.

"What does it matter?"Adora' s eyebrows furrowed together as the sound of the microwave door slamming shut was their only answer. When Catra wouldnt look their way , they rose from the couch and leaned against the counter that marked the division between the kitchen and living room. They wouldnt be ignored.

"It doesnt."Catra quickly replied, unable to meet Adora' s steel blue gaze. She focused on the microwave, willing the damn thing to heat her leftovers faster so she could flee this situation.

"Okay ."

"Okay ."

A tense silence broke out over the pair. Catra finally decided her meal was warm enough, whatever, and took the stupid burrito from the microwave. The bite she crammed into her mouth was an uncomfortable mix of both too hot and too cold and really was pretty gross. But Adora was just *looking* at her and that was even weirder.

Finally, timed perfectly so that Catra was certain to choke on a lukewarm glob of beans and rice, Adora opened their mouth to speak. "Look, Catra, I dont know what your plans for break are," Catra snorted, now chewing around a particularly stubborn piece of carne asada. Plans? She didnt have plans per se, but being alone in the apartment sure as fuck was part of them. Looks like she had to

suck it up and just let that one go already. "But I won't like, be in your way or anything. I won't bother you." Adora frowned as they said the last part, covering their flash of hurt with a half shrug. It was extra pathetic when they accidentally used their bad shoulder to do so and winced audibly. Fucking hell.

After a few more seconds of stubborn chewing, Catra swallowed. She stared down into her leftovers, painfully aware that she was being an absolute asshole over nothing and for no good reason. Ugh. Grudgingly, she said with a sigh, "You don't bother me, dummy."

Then quietly, almost embarrassed, Catra repeated, "I just didn't think anyone else would be here over break."

"I'm going to skip over the part where I ask again why it matters and just say... Sorry? I guess?"

"Don't apologize." Catra picked up her plate and carried it to the living room, just sort of plopping down on the nearest seat. She was being so stupid, but couldn't bring herself to stop. With no small amount of effort, Catra regained some amount of composure and in the most even tone she could manage, muttered, "I don't have any plans for break, so you being here is whatever. You live here, so don't like... Hide or something dumb like that. I was just gonna play some games today." Probably most of her time off would be spent that way, if Catra were being honest.

"Oh."

Adora looked equal parts confused and relieved, not that Catra was any different. She just wasn't expecting anyone else to be here and wasn't exactly thrilled at being caught wearing her third most embarrassing pair of boxer briefs by anyone, let alone Adora. Speaking of, she should probably change at some point, no matter how ridiculously soft they were.

"So, uhh, what were you going to play?" Adora asked tentatively, almost as if they were feeling out the boundaries of Catra's attempted truce. Catra didn't blame their hesitance, even if she was inwardly smacking herself for being so curt at just being caught off guard.

"Witcher III, Wild Hunt. The second season of the show is out, so it got me in the mood to play the best game in the series." Truthfully, Catra ranked it as one of the best RPGs ever created. She could probably play every waking hour of her break and probably just scratch the surface of that magnificent beast since she of course had all the accompanying expansions. The show was pretty fucking awesome too; watching the new season was definitely in the plans for her upcoming free time.

"Ohhhh, I know that one, kinda! Glimmer and Bow watched. It's got that guy, Gerald. Hmm. Fuck." They had dropped their voice ridiculously low, trying to mimic the surly, golden-eyed monster hunter.

Catra quirked a smile at the lame impression, rolling her eyes. "Geralt. But yeah, that's the one."

"Cool. Sounds fun."

Another few moments of silence, not quite as weighty as before, passed between them. With a quick clear of her throat, Catra asked, "D'you wanna, I dunno, watch me?" She was only nervous because she'd been such a jerk just minutes ago. It was going to be a really fucking awkward couple of weeks if she didn't continue to play nice with her roommate, not to mention Catra was over throwing misplaced anger Adora's way. They didn't need any more of that crap and neither did she.

"Sure!" Adora reclaimed their spot on Glimmer's couch, now a happy little puppy dog to be included in something. As Catra booted up her Xbox, they asked, "Is that Java...Javier. That's the witcher' dude in the game too? I liked him. Totally had the hots for

Geralt, which I mean as gay as I am. Kinda get it." They shrugged, chuckling unabashedly at their admittance. Catra agreed. Beautiful people were beautiful people, regardless. And Henry Cavill was a beautiful, beautiful man.

"Jaskier is the character in the show . And in the game." Catra stole another quick bite of her food as she loaded her game. "He goes by the name Dandelion. By choice."

"Wow. That's something, all right." Adora blinked at the information, then giggled. After they had listened to the recap that played as part of the load screen, they said, "I didn't understand any of that. What's going on?"

Catra was a little surprised that Adora was *that* interested, but she did her best to sketch out the main story plot of the game so far. When the questions only continued as she rode around on Roach, Catra found herself explaining more and more, like what was going on in the side quest she had just finished about some wraith on a haunted island that had died from being eaten alive by rats. The afternoon passed quickly with Adora's little gags and squeaks as the various unholy creatures Geralt was paid to dispose of popped out and startled them. By the time she saved and quit for the night, Catra had to admit it wasn't a half-bad way to start winter break.

By day four of recess from classes, Catra knew she had to leave the apartment, at least for a little while. She hadn't been letting herself completely decompose in front of various screens, be it her phone, computer, TV, Switch. But instead filled in a good chunk of her free hours with stuff like reading, sketching, listening to music, and of course, plenty of sweet, sweet naps. Sometimes Adora was around and sometimes they weren't; it was beyond Catra what the overachiever managed to find to fill up their schedule when almost nothing was left open on campus, but kinda like during the semester,

the two of them were largely ships passing each other in the night. At least the harbors held friendly waters.

Adora was just finishing up washing the dishes from their lunch when Catra came out of her bedroom in real clothes, like *jeans* , and headed towards the shoe rack where amazingly Adora's sneakers had ended up being stored for most of this week. Dishes washed and items placed where they belonged? Maybe Sparkles and Scorpia were just bad influences on them.

"Hey! Where ya off to?"

"Not sure." Catra laced up her thick soled, black boots. She loved these fucking things, not just because of how they looked on her (hot), but it was almost ridiculous how confident they could make her feel. Lounge pants and ratty t-shirts were fun for a few days here and there, but there was something to be said for dressing like a functional human being once more. "Might just like, walk around for a bit. Walls are kinda closing in on me."

"Yeah, I totally get it." Adora smiled knowingly. "Coach has had me holed up in the office, rebinding the 'Official Playbook', throwing in all her new formations and retiring the old ones, not to mention doing some other admin-y stuff for the team. It's honestly been... boring as hell."

"Shit, that's where you've been running off to this week?" Catra blinked, then shot her roommate an incredulous look. "Shouldn't she be doing that- or maybe the team captain?"

"Oh, um, well I kind of volunteered. I have to go that way for PT for my shoulder and for check-ups. Which actually they said I can have more time out of the sling starting today!" Adora cheerfully reported in a slight ramble. Catra nodded her agreement that that was definitely a positive and raised an eyebrow once she noticed a small creeping blush appear across Adora's cheeks. "And since this is Huntara's senior year, her last semester playing"…

"Y. ou're trying to suck up and look good so Netty makes you captain."Catra put the pieces together from there, the enby bashfully admitting their ambition to be named the head of the team come next year. "Okay , fair. But cant that shit wait until after break? I mean, fuck, are either one of them even *on campus* right now to see all your stunning extra effort?"

After an uncomfortable pause, Adora hung their head slightly and scrunched up one eye in a wince as they confessed further. "No, they're not. And it' s not so much as volunteering as I have access to the office and Coach mentioned wanting to reorganize things once or twice and um"…

"W ow, you really cant relax, can you?"Catra laughed, the sound tinged with genuine affection. Only Adora…

They gave a self-effacing grin in reply, joining with a few chuckles of their own at their nature. "Guilty ."

"All right, c'mon, dummy ."Catra slung her leather jacket over her shoulder, uncertain if the shining sun outside was a good indicator of the temperature or not. Best to be prepared. She jerked her head towards the door and rolled her eyes. "Y ou're coming with me. And no, we're not going anywhere near the rink, the athletic of fices, or even the rec center. You need a break, seriously."

"Oh? Oh! Okay , yeah, um, that sounds fun!"Adora' s eyes were bright, bright blue. "Just give me five, all right? I'm gonna take of f the sling. We probably wont be gone more than an hour , right?"

"It' s unstructured free time; who knows!"Catra waved her hands mockingly, her voice full of faked wonder and mystery. "There' s a big, big world out there. We might not even come back until 3. PM!"

"Oh. In that case I better bring it with me. Ill be back in a jf f!"Adora dashed off to their room, leaving Catra to shake her head fondly. Truly, only Adora.

Campus was closed, but the small college town of Brightmoon was a little more lively. That was all relative to begin with considering even during the swing of the school year there wouldnt be all that much exciting to do on a Wednesday in the early afternoon. But there was only a bit of chill in the air, really about the worst they ever got during the Brightmoon "winters", and Catra was enjoying the chance to stretch her legs. She purposely avoided any area that might get Adora thinking that they needed to run off to take care of "one last thing" and just in general tried to get them of f campus as quickly as possible. Adora didnt seem to mind;they trotted along happily next to Catra, talking about how pleased they were to not have a sling digging into their neck at the moment or bunching up the arms of their oversized mint sweatshirt.

"Glad youre feeling better ." Catra said, meaning it. The injury was never that bad, at least from what Adora reported, and she just had to hope the dummy was being truthful, for their own sake. But since there wasnt anything pressing going on, nothing that would make Adora feel the need to push themself to be one hundred percent, Catra believed it really was on the mend.

Looking around the little downtown, Catra weighed her options. They probably did need groceries, but eh, what was a couple more days of take out and scrounging? The head shop was a nah;Adora wasnt much of a smoker, no matter how hilarious they were when stoned. The bars were all closed this early and definitely would pay attention to a couple of underaged students bold enough to try and drink on break. That really only left the coffee shop.

"Hey , I need a boost. Down for Scrawl?" Catra vaguely gestured down the main drag of the town towards the bright yellow building that was the last bastion for students who needed caffeine during a cram session. It was open practically 24/7 and had great roasts with quick bites. The tables all had a large roll of white paper and baskets of crayons so patrons could color in (usually lewd) masterpieces or have a place to quickly jot down some numbers while figuring out a particularly complicated equation.

"Sure! Man, I tried to get in there last week to study and it was *packed* . It'll be nice to go in there during the off season."

"Shit, I don't even try after October . Third floor of the library is better; it's a ghost town. If I really need to concentrate, I'll ask Spinny for a study room up there."

"Wait, you can rent rooms in the library?" Adora blinked at this bit of information that was most definitely covered during the campus orientation. "Huh. That's probably good to know."

"Ya think?" Catra panned, opening the door to the shop. The invigorating scent of coffee filled her nose, making a pretty good afternoon somehow even better. "Seriously , I have no idea how you're managing to make the Deans List. I mean, your desk alone… It's like you set up an obstacle course for yourself."

"Heh, well, the training never ends-..." Adora announced in their best military sergeant voice. The impressions were so bad, but never failed to make Catra smile.

"What can I get you ladies?" A bored, almost verging on irritated voice interrupted from behind the counter. Jay Lashor, disgustingly known as *Tung* by all his fellow frat brothers. Catra wouldn't even waste the breath to say she hated him, the guy was so utterly useless.

"I need a minute to decide." Catra replied, her voice cool and edged. "And *they* do too."

The work's head tilted at the inflection, but he otherwise ignored it. "Whatever . You chicks can grab me when you're ready ."

He disappeared to the back before Catra could jump the counter , ready to smack that empty-headed grin from his face. *Chicks* . No way that wasn't entirely intentional; how one instigating fuck could get the final word in. Lashor had been in that same exact Student Success Seminar as Catra freshman year when all the students had

to give an introduction the first day. Adora's they/them had been a bare, flustered whisper at the time, but now they could shout "E-N" and at least five voices across the quad would answer "B-Y!"

"Cat- it's okay." A small squeeze on her shoulder interrupted Catra's seething, all the machinations surrounding retaliation and revenge momentarily halted. "You've got that "I'm going to destroy the world and watch it burn." look in your eye."

"No, it's really fucking not. That was completely intentional and he just, just-"…

"Yeah, I know. But I also don't care." Adora leaned back on their heels. "I mean, sure it sucks, but asshats like that just also aren't worth the effort. His choice to be ignorant doesn't change my identity, y'know?"

Catra's indignation was somewhat mullfied by Adora's calm and clear cadence, how sure they looked even in this decently shitty moment.

"And Jay is just a class A prick." Adora laughed, the matter settled in their mind. They quickly scanned the menu board to pick out their order and called out for a worker to return. Catra thought it was particularly wise that Lashor hadn't chosen to amble out once more. She really didn't need to be at the scene of another scene at Scrawl, no matter how justified.

"Thanks for that." Adora said after a few minutes of companionable silence. They were seated together on one of the plush couches that lined the shop and mostly had the place to themselves. It was peaceful, even if Catra was lowkey scanning the counter to see if perhaps her double-hot Americano would "accidentally" be spilled. And if the scalding coffee just happened to catch Lashor right in the face, well…

Shaking herself free from her thoughts around dickwads who needed skin grafts for Solstice, Catra raised an eyebrow. "For what?"

"I don't think Jay really gets it. But you, you've always been really great about my pronouns. So, thanks for that."

"Adora, you don't have to *thank me* for not being an asshole about an integral part of yourself. Sheesh, dummy, have a little more self-respect than that. Demand your own best treatment and don't compromise." Catra bit into the words, irritated she had to be saying them at all. How many other ignorant shitheads out there took one look at Adora's long hair and just *assumed*. It infuriated Catra to no end. Sure they looked killer in a dress when they wanted to, but being nonbinary didn't automatically demand androgeny. "Besides, how couldn't I? You're about the biggest thembo on the face of the planet."

Adora gave a belly laugh, to the point of needing to set down their hot chocolate with extra whip, lest they end up with the gooey melted cup of sugar down their front. "Yeah. You know those videos where it's like, 'If only I had a big, strong they/them to help!' That's me." The beaming grin of pride they flashed only served to prove their point.

"Videos. Are you a million years old? That's a tiktok thing."

"Tiks. Vids. What's the difference?"

Catra had no answer to that but to shake her head and laugh. Only Adora.

In the days following the outing for coffee, Adora was more present around the apartment. Maybe they'd decided to actually listen to Catra and at least *try* to relax during their time off or maybe they finally finished the meticulous organizing that they had tasked themselves with. Catra didn't ask, but she didn't necessarily hate having Adora around. They were a complete goof, but had a good sense of when Catra needed to be alone to do her own thing and

when she was up for company. And the dummy did always know how to make her laugh…

Catra was still left with plenty of time to get up to her own devices. She'd temporarily moved on from the Witcher and was focusing full force on her current great video game love, Hades. That game was an absolute bitch in the best ways;an exceedingly well done rogue-lite with some of the best characters she'd ever seen. Catra had two goals as a result of her many, many runs: 1. She *would* see Achilles and Patroclus reunited, that titular bastard of the underworld be damned, and 2. She would absolutely cosplay at least one of these fucking gods because their design was just too good. Ares was currently her top choice;a quick buzz on the side and some extra length up top and Catra already practically had the hair.

"Goddammit!"Catra groaned, throwing her head back into a sulk that even Sparkles would be impressed by.

Adora wandered in at the expletive, taking one look at Zagreus floating upwards on the screen, surrounded by blood and the ominous reminder, THERE IS NO ESCAPE, before clucking their tongue consolingly. "Aw www. Did that rat bastard Theseus get ya again?"

"No. Meg."Catra grumbled, ignoring Hypnos and whatever "comedic"dialogue he had for Zag in favor of adjusting a few things in the mirror. Switching from Stubborn Defiance had just been plain stupid of her.

"Wow, really?"

Catra didn't miss the small note of judgement in their voice. Wow, talk about uncalled for. Adora tried to play once and barely made it through Tartarus before Tisiphone the "muuuuuurderer" queen swiftly handed them their ass. Catra didn't have the patience today for any backseat gaming. "I had the heat turned way up, sheesh. Cut me a break. That whip is a bitch."…

"Correction: she's the bitch and that whip." Adora paused for a moment, then a truly smug smirk appeared for just a flash before their face went completely blank. Catra was almost worried the dummy had short circuited or something before she heard, "Mommy? Sorry . Mommy? Sorry . Mommy"…

"Oh fucking hell. We never should have done that tiktok binge last night, seriously." Really Catra had done this to herself; giving Adora hours and hours worth of ammo to quote out at random. At least this one was used with the right context.

Catra threw a pillow, her favorite one that supported her lower back just right during long hours of sitting, directly at the thirsty idiot's face. Adora caught it with ease and stuck out their tongue in reply, waggling their eyebrows outrageously. "She's hot, what can I say? There's just something about mean girls who are secretly total softies on the inside. Does it for me. Bad." They looked away for a minute and coughed.

"Thanks for that. I really needed to know ." Catra mumbled, now just mindlessly kicking the crap out of Skelly with the twin fists. She could start another run, of course, but after losing in Tartarus for fuck's sake…

"Ahem, well, yknow ." Adora followed up so eloquently with a few lingering chuckles. When nothing but Skelly's demands for Zag to continue to thrash him filled the room for almost a solid minute, Adora cleared their throat. "Hey uh, do you have anything that's… two player?"

Catra stopped mid combo at the question, thinking hard. Of course she had multiplayer options, though with gaming the way it was right now, couch co-op was a little more limited. Quickly flicking to her homepage and reviewing her list of titles, Catra easily settled on one.

"Hmmmm, let me see. You might be missing the rink after so long, so yeah. I think I got something for us." Super Blood Hockey was

manic, ridiculous, and at least for a little while tonight, would be a great distraction from failing so hard at Hades. Adora would *probably* be able to follow along with how to play;really it was closer to frantic button masher than actual skill. If nothing else, it would be funny as hell to watch them flail around in between fistfights.

They ended up playing way, way longer than Catra expected them too. As predicted, Adora was suitably lost as hell at first, a cascade of protests and exclamations of "Hey! Not fair, what button do I push? Where's my player? The puck? Help!" making the whole thing even sweeter to partake in. Catra cackled as they beat on one another;actually making a goal was pretty secondary to the pixelated blood that spilled whenever they got into a fight. Maybe they should do some Smash Bros next.

"Okay, okay. I need a break." Adora surrendered after losing yet again, setting down their controller. "At least with this one. Why does it move so fast;I can barely follow the puck. Fuck!"

"All part of the game there, champ. You'd think a star athlete like you would have a leg up, but huh. Guess not." Catra shot a dazzling smile their way, just barely ducking to miss the pillow that had been volleyed back at her head. "Hey now, watch that shoulder! You wanna be back on the ice in a couple weeks, right? You are Brightmoon's best, after all."

"Yeah, yeah. It's fine." Adora grumbled, rising from the couch to stretch.

While raising their arm up to demonstrate the returned full mobility of their shoulder, a slice of ridiculously toned stomach peered out at Catra. Not that she had been watching that closely or anything. That would be...weird to do to a friend. A friend *and* roommate. Fuck.

"Also I'm not the 'best'. I mean, yeah, okay, I'm pretty decent-"...

"What's this? Modesty from Adora Grayson? Are you feeling okay? Maybe you should lay down." Catra shook off the momentary daze,

firing back as quickly as she could to cover herself.

"Oh ha, ha. You're so clever. Playing at the college level has shown me just where I stand, seriously. Some of these players in the division." Adora trailed off, then shrugged. "They blow me out of the water."

"If you say so, Dor. I haven't really seen it since high school, so." Catra also decided that some full body movement might not be the worst thing and slunk off to the kitchen. The fridge was fuller than last week after one splurging grocery trek for snacks and real sustenance in order to tide both her and Adora over for the rest of break. Now if she didn't actually have to *cook* it, that would be incredible. Breaks were made for laziness.

"Catra?"

Adora's voice sounded behind her as Catra dug around for a suitable snack. The cubed cheese was definitely the winner, no real contest. The bag was grabbed and Catra made her way back to the couch she'd had her ass plastered to all afternoon. "Yeah?"

"What happened back then?"

Before Catra could buy a vowel or ask the fuck, Adora elaborated, drawing in a deep, fortifying breath. "What I mean is, why did you stop playing hockey before college? We used to have so much fun back in high school, even as opponents! Seeing you out on the rink was like..." They shrugged, tips of their ears going red. "I mean, I know we see each like every day at the apartment now, but, um. Yeah."

Catra sighed, looking away from fumbling, earnest enby she resided with. How to explain something that had no easy answers? A lot of the circumstances were completely behind Catra's control at the time, but it wasn't just hockey that Catra lost as she got herself in order during the transition from high school to college. Most days she could barely get out of bed. Only video games held some

interest for her;the pixels didnt care how long it had been since she last showered. That interest held on over the years, then sparked a number of other things like robotics, art, puzzles, DnD.All the stuf f that marked Catra as a way better adjusted person now . I just couldnt anymore. Realized that it.W asnt my thing."

Adora frowned, their mouth opening and closing several times before ultimately coming to a close. They so obviously wanted to know more, but was trying so hard to respect that Catra might not want to rehash old wounds today. That consideration was the only thing that fueled Catra to keep talking.

"Look, you peaced out of Freighton, not that I fucking blame you." Catra shifted on the couch, decidedly uncomfortable as she thumbed over the joystick on her Joycon, her nibbles of cheese forgotten. Fuck, this was heavy for something obviously spurred by a game of Super Blood Hockey. She and Adora had already had a lot of these conversations, about Adora "leaving" her during the middle of high school. They happened back during freshman year when they learned that they were not only attending the same college, but largely had the same set of classes, and would need to learn to coexist with one another, for both their sake and well-being. "And then things were yknow , weird, between us for a while."

"But we got better ."Adora said carefully , looking Catra's way. Their expression clearly showed they needed confirmation that this was indeed how things had played out, as if living together without any major bloodshed for months now wasnt a big enough clue.

"Y eah, dummy. We did."Catra was certain to smile, anything to ease Adora's anxiousness. It had been a hard fought battle to get where they were now, roommates of all things, but she counted Adora as one of those people she maybe, kind of didnt always completely hate.

The tension held in Adora's posture visibly lessened at the reassurance.

"But that's not where I was going. Look, I'm sure you heard a lot about the shit that went down right before senior year of high school. Rumors or whatever. But when Weaver-..." Catra swallowed, willing her face to stay even. That bitch held no power over her any more. Not from the grave. "When she wasn't in the picture anymore, it's true that Scorp's moms took me in. Which was like, fucking world's above that luxury life my oh so doting guardian provided for me, but it was still fucking *rough* to get used to everything new..."

"I'm sorry... I should have been there for you." Adora mumbled, hands fidgeting with the fringe on a throw pillow. Their eyes were troubled, holding onto a weight they truly, truly didn't need to.

"Hush, dummy. Seriously. We've been through this. You did what was right for you and I can't be mad at that. 'Things happen the way they're meant to', 'opportunities to grow' and all that crap. Blah, blah blah. Plus, I mean," Catra ran her hand through her short crop of hair, weirdly soothed by the feel of the sheared sides against her fingers, "Just like you said, we got better. Focus on now with me, okay?"

Adora's returning smile was a little threadbare, but Catra could see it growing in strength the longer they sat with it. "Okay. The now. But um, if you're in an okay spot, I was sort of asking about...the before?"

Catra sighed, but they'd already started this journey. "Yeah, I'm okay. Why did I quit? I liked playing hockey... but realized it wasn't gonna *get me* anywhere, y'know? I'm really trying to focus on my studies instead. Lame as hell, I know, but-"...

"I don't think it's lame. Catra, you're brilliant." Adora quickly cut in, shaking their head resolutely. "I mean, seriously. It's not just that you remember like, everything you've ever read, it's the *way* you put it all together in the end. Your mind is just"...

Adora lifted their head, now looking Catra dead in the eyes. With not even a trace of insincerity or embarrassment they said, "You're

amazing. And I can't wait to see you succeed."

Catra felt like there suddenly wasn't enough air in the whole apartment. For most of her life, Catra and her abilities had been ignored; downplayed at best and viciously, cruelly decimated at worst. Her relationship with Adora had been able to heal only because Catra had put the effort into healing herself first, but some days, she still didn't trust the strides and progress that she'd made. Part of her still expected to wake up and see it all gone in an instant; her grades, her upcoming (blessedly paid) internship in the actual field she was working on a degree in. Probably because of some dumb decision Catra made along the way, like pulling the wrong switch at the most horrible time.

So to hear someone so easily and plainly say that she would *succeed*? And that they wanted to stick around to see it for themselves? It was all just so... much. So Adora.

"Thanks for telling me that, really. I'm sure this was all a little more than you really wanted to get into tonight or ever. And yeah. Sometimes. Sometimes I wonder how far the sports will get me too." Adora admitted with a slight frown. "But I like it and even if I'm not like pro level, it keeps me focused. Sharp. When I'm out on the ice or half-court, the everyday stressful kind of stuff doesn't matter, y'know?"

Catra did get it; it was how she felt when she conquered a particularly tricky puzzle or made it out of a rough DnD session with her insanely badass rogue somehow still alive. Or when she actually finished a drawing, as few and far between as that could be. But those distractions, no, those *passions*, made things bearable. And it was different for everyone, with no possible right or wrong. Maybe sports had been ultimately jettisoned for Catra, but Adora thrived under the lights and at screaming cheers of their fans. It was where they belonged, at least for this stage of their life. And maybe Catra would make an effort in the future to watch them succeed in the rink or on the court, just as they had so readily asserted they'd do for her.

Catra and Adora spent the last few days leading up to the Solstice still gaming together. Super Blood Hockey had been phased out by For the King, a virtual tabletop RPG that was at least more Adora's speed. They maybe didn't get everything about initiative or stats, but they at least could smack the shit out of enemies with a big ass battleaxe while playing as the blacksmith. They got more into the game than Catra had been anticipating at least, so much that Adora expressed interest in coming to a real-life DnD session with her sometime in the spring. Huh. That was…cool.

Their actual holiday was quiet; each exchanged small roommate-level token gifts with one another and treated themselves to a pot of melted cheese, bread, and fruits for dinner. Fondue was so easy and yet so tasty.

To pass the time while they recovered from their cheese-induced comas, they jumped back into the land of Fahrul to avenge the slain king. Their chaos was at reasonable levels, every character had devoted themselves to a sanctum, and only three lives had been lost (having their fighter lose their sword to an acid jelly certainly hadn't made for an easy dungeon sweep earlier) so far. Catra was in the zone, ready to *beat* this addictive little roguelike.

"Ah, shit, Scorpia's calling. Here, lemme just pause real quick." Catra rolled her eyes at the phone; of course Scorp would break all the social conventions of their generation and not just text her a "Happy Solstice!" and a GIF. An actual phone call, really?

"Catra!" A booming voice almost identical to her daughter's sounded on the other end of the line when Catra answered. "Happy Solstice."

"Oh, hey Garnet. Happy Solstice. How's it going?" All right, Scorp got some points back. Catra was sure that Garnet had asked her friend to dial, not trusting her ability to use her own cell for the task.

"W ell it's after 5 o'clock on a holiday . Linda's halfway through a bottle of red and dinner is still a bunch of separate, raw ingredients."A cacophony of laughter followed, so loud that Catra had to hold the phone away from her ear. "Just a typical holiday f ound these parts. Except I dont have my favorite sous chef here to help me bring it all together!What' s a mom to do, seriously"…

Adora's eyes flicked over to the phone at that;Garnet' s normal speaking voice negated the need for speakerphone. Catra couldnt read the expression on their face and keep up with Scorpia's boisterous mom at the same time. She almost completely missed hearing, "... time should we expect you on New Y ears"?

"Oh, uh. Im not coming-..."

"Catra,"Garnet' s voice was sweet as ever, but Catra recognized the steel core below. "What time will you be in next week?W e want *both* our girls home, even j ust for a q ick visit."

Her chest seized at the word;Catra had to shut her eyes for a moment at the weight of it. Scorpia and her family had given her so much.So much that could never be repaid. She swallowed and fumbled out, "I-I was planning on j ust staying in Brightmoon this year . With Adora."

"Adora!"Came Garnet' s happy cry. "Oh, how are they? I havent seen them since move-in back in August.Oh they simply must come too. Yup, that's it. Well have everyone in for New Y ears then ship you all back to get educated. You two can take the train in and then Scorpll drive the four of you back. Perfect!"

"Four"?Catra asked weakly .

"Do you *really* think Scorpia and Perfuma could stay away from one another for three whole weeks?And miss one of the most romantic holidays of the year?"Her best friend' s mother laughed, the sound knowing and full of love. "Shell fly in from visiting her folks on Monday. Now, as for you and Adora, how about we see about some

tickets for a Wednesday arrival? Just a couple days with mom and ma. Then well let you all head back to school."

Catra knew that it was pointless to protest when she heard furious typing on the other end. Couldnt work her iPhone, but you could tear Garnet's Mac from her cold, dead hands. T. rain tickets were certainly already being purchased. She looked up at her somewhat dumbfounded roommate and shrugged. "Got plans for New Y ears?

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Surprisingly, Adora was only a little hesitant to agree to spending the holiday at Scorpia's. They mostly seemed intrigued by the prospect and highly flattered at being included. There was no question that they would join since Garnet had indeed bought two train tickets; Adora wasn't the type to allow someone to waste money on them and then not follow through. Sparkles' family must be a bunch of complete and total drags though since they hadn't wanted to spend the holidays with them, but were so cool with tagging along to celebrate with Catra's bunch of goons.

The train ride took under two hours. Garnet, Linda, Scorpia, *and* Perfuma were all waiting for them at the station when they arrived. Catra tolerated the plethora of crushing hugs from the three ridiculously tall women she had lived with for a couple years during high school and now while on summer break. She quirked a little grin when she saw Adora get swept up by them too. It was nice, like something out of a cheesy Hallmark movie.

Once at Garnet and Linda's house, there was the obligatory chit chat and semester catch up- what classes were they taking in the Spring semester, how did their grades end up for the Fall, report something new and interesting Adora and Catra had learned in each one of their classes this time around…

Scorp and Fuma just chortled at both their expenses, having already run that particular gamet on Monday when Perfuma had arrived. Catra had been expecting it, but Adora was a little flummoxed by all the attention. But at the shy report of their academic success so far, Garnet and Linda literally cheering for Adora, showering them with praise. They adjusted quickly . It was interesting for Catra to watch,

only a little humiliating when the attention was turned to her and her academic progress. By the end of the conversation however, she conceded that she might have been a little off in thinking Adora was the only one who'd ever believed that she would succeed.

From there Garnet pulled Catra into the kitchen, inviting Adora to tag along if they wanted. Cooking together had been so important during Catra's adjustment to living with Scorpia, Garnet, and Linda. To learn that food was something to be shared, not just hoarded and withheld as punishment, not to mention experiencing the joy of preparing it with someone and for others. Garnet was a lot, Scorpia's apple sure didn't fall far from that tall, tall tree, but her patience in the kitchen and genuine excitement at teaching her culinary skills to someone else was a turning point for Catra and her general well-being. Aprons were dumb though; just brush the flour off or go change, seriously.

Adora watched the dinner prep more than helped, looking rather bemused as Catra effortlessly whisked, sautéed, and seasoned. They were supposed to be slicing up veggies for the salad, but after Catra had caught them with an empty-headed smile spread across their face for the umpteenth time instead of watching the blade that was dangerously close to their fingers, she confiscated any sharp objects from the dummy's immediate area.

"You like to cook." Adora stated shortly thereafter. That sweet, weird little smile of theirs was back, full force, now paired with a tilt of their head. "Huh."

"A little." Catra glanced up from slicing tomatoes, making sure to keep them large enough so Scorpia could easily and politely remove them from her portion of the salad. Not liking raw (garden-grown in the summer) tomatoes was so weird, but her friend also willingly ate *mushrooms* so sometimes there was no accounting for good taste. "So?"

"Nothing!" Adora drummed their fingers on the counter, fidgeting for a moment under Catra's gaze. With a visible swallow they said, "I'm

just surprised you don't do it more often when we're at home. Not that you don't ever cook, but, y'know…"

"Yeah, well. It's not my fault we have a shoebox kitchen with like no counter space in our crummy apartment. I do the best I can with what I got. Also, sue me, I was taking over twenty credit hours this semester. Some days I barely had time to eat, let alone cook."

"I absolutely did not hear that." Garnet, busy at the stovetop behind Catra, called out, "Because I know I taught both of my girls a bunch of quick, practically no prep, nutritious dishes to keep their brains fueled and their tummies full. So of course *no one* ever skips out on meals."

Catra rolled her eyes affectionately and returned to her task of chopping.

"You just seem really…in the zone right now…" Adora remarked, their eyebrows furrowed slightly, like they were still working out the mysteries behind a culinary Catra.

"Got a problem with that?" Catra arched, tiring of whatever was confusing the hell out of Adora in this pretty mundane situation. She knew more than just how to order DoorDash. So what?

"No! It's cute." Adora said quickly…, then trailed off, their eyes growing wide and mouth snapping shut with an audible pop. Aware of their own sudden awkwardness, they cleared their throat and tried to regain their footing. "I mean, it's cool! C-cool that you know how to do all this stuff and everything. Hey…, what's that?"

"Uh. A vegetable peeler?" The oven must have finished preheating because Catra's cheeks felt rather warm. She dimly heard Garnet chuckling over *something* behind her, but refused to acknowledge it whatsoever. Catra kept her voice even as she explained, "It's for the asparagus. Ends are sometimes too tough. Peeling helps."

“Wow! See, I wouldn’t even know what asparagus looks like let alone how to cook it. Would you just look at that. Do you have a bathroom?”

Adora was looking wildly around the kitchen as if they expected a door to the facilities to appear from nowhere. Catra was this close to fucking with them, saying no before pointing them towards the oak tree out back, but she caught sight of Garnet literally wiping a tear from the corner of her eye, just barely holding back a huge, dopey grin and simply couldn’t deal any more. She gave Adora directions to the nearest bathroom, one of two that came equipped with the house, and concentrated on making dinner finally fucking happen.

Garnet had sidled up next to Catra at the counter, carving the roast that was the main event of their meal. Out of the corner of her mouth she murmured, “Guess I don’t have to ask if you’re kissing someone at midnight tomorrow, eh.”

“Quiet, you.” Catra growled, the sound low and for anyone who didn’t really know her, seemingly dangerous. They really needed to shut off the fucking oven already, because her face was *burning*. “It’s not like that. At all.”

“Oh, honey.” Garnet tsked, following it with a full-bellied laugh. “You can lie to yourself all you want, but not to momma.”

Catra promptly set down her knife at that point and stomped off to set the table. Ugh. She really should have stayed home.

Dinner was uneventful and delicious, the kitchen crew receiving practically a standing ovation for their efforts. Adora was unusually quiet during the meal, but when Catra tapped the side of their ankle, startling them out of their thoughts, and asked in a hiss if they were okay, they perked up and engaged with the table for the remainder of

the meal. Catra was certain it was a cover, the dummy forcing themselves to pretend, and she simply wasn't having it.

She strong-armed her way past the suggestion for after dinner board games with coffee and dessert to follow. Adora was her guest, basically, and she hadn't even given them a chance to settle into the spare room yet. Both of their bags were still sitting right by the front door, so Scorpia could cool it with begging to play Codenames, Cosmic Encounter, Sheriff of Nottingham…

Catra nodded her head towards the stairs, beckoning for Adora to follow. Her room and the remaining guest room were at the very end of the hall, past the near floor to ceiling collage of family photos taken over the years that was plastered along one section of the wall. Catra could tell Adora was desperate to pour over each image and she would sure as fuck point out the most embarrassing ones so she and Adora could have something to really razz their other roommate later, but not tonight.

"Okay , uh, here's where you can stay."Catra opened the door to the lilac painted walls of the spare bedroom. It was a little cramped inside;serving both as a space for Linda to display her vast collection of My Little Pony figures and memorabilia, as well as the spot for a guest to lay their head. Catra was a little embarrassed as she beheld all the colorful manes with their various cutie marks on the shelves. It was unnerving to have that many plastic, equine eyes staring at you. "But, um, I'm right next door . So if you want I can sleep in here instead if these are creep-"…

"Horsies!"Adora exclaimed, their eyes bright. "W ow!What an amazing collection."

Catra gave a soft smile as Adora made their way into the room, looking at each individual figure and excitedly calling out every pony they recognized by name. Any weirdness from being downstairs with everyone had disappeared;Adora was back to being their normal, goofy self again. Good. There would still have been the time to take them back to campus tonight if Catra had bullied Scorpia hard

enough about borrowing her car, but she was glad to not have to make the drive.

"Okay , well Im just right on the other side of this wall," Catra jerked her head that way, "So, I mean. Grab me if you need anything. Bathroom is across the way. Yes. We have two here. Amazing."

Adora giggled at their own silliness earlier, the sound slipping into an almost shy smile. "Thanks, Catra. This has been really , really nice."

"Eh, dont thank me yet. W e still have the holiday to contend with." And breakfasts, and quality time with the fam, and the long, long goodbyes at the end. "But Im glad youre having an okay time."

"Me too."

The pair stood together for a few minutes, Adora absently rubbing their arm, each not quite able to meet the other 's eye, but also unwilling to move. Catra finally stopped being so dumb for no reason and said, "Uh, I mean. It is kinda early . Im sure everyone downstairs is already knee deep in like Power Grid or Ticket to Ride. Dyou maybe wanna get settled in and then play-..."

"For the King? Y es! W e were so close this last time. It's killing me that we cant make it past that damn tower!"

The corner of Catra's mouth ticked up at Adora's frustration. "Y eah, I know. Doesnt seem like it would be that hard. Maybe well drop the inflation rates in the shops, make it a little easier on ourselves." It would mean a reduced lore payout, but Catra had already unlocked most of the stuff the lorebooks could buy. "Just text me or knock or whatever when youre ready . See ya in a bit."

They did not beat this run and failed pretty quickly in the next. Catra heard Garnet and Linda make their way up to bed and shortly thereafter, a text from Scorpia came through inviting her and Adora down for a few rounds of Cards Against Humanity. Back when they first got it, theyd tried to play it with Scorpia' s moms too, but after

Linda chose (Garnet's) Fingering' to win on the prompt 'A girl' s best friend' and the two wives cackled heartily , making salacious grins at one another as they undoubtedly relived some rather fun moments in their last 25 years of marriage, Catra and Scorpia both vowed never again. Sure, it was completely true, but. T hat was *mom* and *ma* .

It was late in the night when Catra proudly claimed the winning card (Bees? paired with 'The B" in LGBT stands for ') and the group decided that catching a few hours of sleep before mandatory family breakfast was probably wise. Scorpia's room was on the first floor, which Catra always thought was kinda weird, so she and Adora were the only ones to have to trudge up those stairs. Right outside their respective rooms, the pair stopped to catch their breath, trying (and largely failing) to keep their giggling down to 'middle of the night' levels.

'Is it. weird to ask if I can give you a hug"?

The question caught Catra of f guard, her hand resting on the doorknob to her room, now fiddling with it as she considered. Of course they'd hugged before, but it had been a long, long time ago. A different life practically…

Still, it was the holidays and Adora was a mensch for putting up with her chosen family's nonsense for hours on end now. Catra smirked, "Only if you make it weird, dummy ."

"W ell, it's me, so"…

Catra opened her arms a bit and Adora just sort of. fell into them, as if they had momentarily forgotten how bodies worked and wanted to make good on their promise that it would end up weird. It probably should be nominated for a top spot in the list of most awkward hugs ever, but it wasn't. Really , really wasn't. Adora was warm and they smelled so good, like spiced vanilla, something that Catra probably should have picked up on before this moment since they lived together, but never had noticed until they were this close to each other. It was no longer than any friendly embrace, but Catra's arms

continued to buzz with the outline of their body long after they'd broken apart.

Only lingering a moment more in the doorways, they whispered goodnight to one another and parted ways until the morning. Catra slowly closed the door to her room, leaning against it for a just second. She looked over towards the room neighboring hers and allowed herself one dumb, giddy smile in private.

Linda was gracious enough to let all the young adults in the house sleep in as late as they wanted- so long as it wasn't past 9am, when breakfast was to be served. Garnet might be a professional chef, but when it came to breakfast food, that was all her wife's doing. Catra came downstairs to the familiar but no less loved scent of bacon, french toast, eggs. Adora for all their manners with being a guest in someone else's home practically mowed Catra down in their haste to investigate the heavenly aromas of the morning meal.

"Coffee?" Linda gestured with the pot as a way of greeting them both.

Catra nodded and before Adora could answer, piped in with, "Tea for Adora. I got it." She moved to the cabinet filled with all the greens, blacks, oolongs, and herbals one could ever want and held up a container of loose leaf vanilla caramel black tea and a box of earl grey Adora's way. "Preference?"

"Vanilla caramel, please and thank you. But no-..."

"Sweetener , yeah." Catra moved to the electric kettle and within three minutes placed a steaming mug in front of Adora to finish steeping. "Enjoy your hot leaf juice."

"Whatever , Zeko. Because your black death beans are so much better."Adora parried, following behind Catra as they moved to the dining room. "Perfect for when you want to feel jittery for twenty minutes and then crash."

"I dont *crash* ."Catra snif fed, eyes closing as she caught the scent of the dark roast. She smiled lightly over the edge of her mug, "I make more before that."

"Good morning, children."Garnet greeted, peering at them from underneath the rim of her reading glasses. She was the picture of vintage domesticity;her wife in the kitchen cooking breakfast as she read the paper at the table in her plush, gray robe. "I trust you two had a good night last night?Seem to have heard an awful lot of giggling coming from somewhere"…

"Ah, shit. Sorry about that."Catra stumbled out, hoping that the tips of her ears going red could be attributed to the hot drink she'd been sipping as if she were a cartoon character.

"I'm sure Ill only hear more tonight."Garnet winked and returned to the printed periodicals, possibly the last one in the neighborhood to not yet go digital. She would move on to catching up with the world on her computer after she had finished with the printed news.

Scorpia and Perfuma came in from the direction of her bedroom at that point, both dressed and ready to face the day. Catra rolled her eyes at the go-getters. Morning people. Ugh. Still, she welcomed their presence for the distraction that it was. Garnet's wink had seemed.Pointed. And it was far too early to handle that crap.

After eating the delicious mounds of breakfast foods that Linda had supplied them with, there was little debate on how to spend the rest of the day. The subject of board games was raised once more and this time, Catra agreed. She glanced at Adora briefly to gauge interest and reaction, but only found them bright and happy at the thought of play.

They fit in a surprising number of games from the mid-morning to the late afternoon, only pausing to heat the leftovers from dinner last night for lunch. It only dawned on her when the sun shone through the window and illuminated Adora's somewhat sleep tousled hair with near golden radiance that neither of them had bothered to shower or dress properly for the day. Wow, they were really comfortable with Scorpia and her family. Huh.

"I think I'm gonna catch a shower ." Catra said, raising her arms up with a big stretch. "Okay , definitely. I stink."

"Glad you said it and not me." Adora teased with a little smirk, playfully wrinkling their nose.

"Better than you after leg day at the gym. Fuck, have to air out the whole damn apartment after."

"These gains come at a price."

They flexed their biceps to demonstrate and Catra. "Well, she might be willing to foot that particular bill. Her friend unsurprisingly had nice arms. Really, ridiculously nice arms. Just a private observation.

It was only a little weird that the thought followed her into the shower.

As soon as Catra was finished cleaning herself up, Adora excused themselves to do the same. It was already almost evening;Garnet was planning a whole array of small bites for them to snack on all night, but largely they were already constructed. Out of habit, Catra still wandered into the kitchen to see if there was anything that needed done.

Garnet glanced up as she approached and half-smiled in greeting. Everything looked well spread out- a charcuterie board, a platter of funky finger sandwiches, dips, fruits, breads. Eating way , way too much was really the best way to bring in the new year.

"So. Less than 8 hours until midnight."

"And?" Catra said carefully , snagging a bit of sharp cheddar from the board and forgoing the crackers to pair with it. They just got in the way of the good stuff.

"Just a friendly reminder that it's bad luck to start the new year without a kiss." Garnet replied innocently , even going so far as to whistle a jaunty little tune as she continued to build tonight's small plate feast. "What a tradition!"

"Do I look like I want anything to do with *tradition*?" Catra grumbled back, pilfering more food in retaliation.

"No. And I'm darn proud of you for it." All traces of the woman's teasing were gone as she said the words. "You're gonna make your own way in the world, Wildcat. Already are. Your ma and I. We're both so proud of who you've become and what you'll do with it."

Catra was suitably stunned by the sudden seriousness, not to mention the fierce pride and uncompromising fondness that came along with it. Linda and Garnet had never been anything less than generous and warm to her, that wild stray that ended up on their doorway after a rather tumultuous storm years ago. It was still humbling to experience every time.

"But you're only kidding yourself here, sweetheart. Your eyes about popped out when Adora showed off those guns." That damnable wink of hers was back, the "audience Aww's" moment between them expiring. "Can't say I blame you. Linda's arms have always made me-..." Garnet fanned herself for a moment with a dish towel, mock panting.

"Gahh! You're impossible!" Catra shot up from her seat, not ready to hear any more in this year or the next. Maybe it was childish, okay *definitely was* , but she also didn't want any comparisons drawn between her and her *friend* and the couple that had been happily married for 20 plus years. It just wasn't the same in the least. Garnet really needed to get it out of her head already about what was happening with her and Adora. Which was *nothing* . Yeah they were getting along better than they ever had before and sure, these past few weeks with the dummy had been an absolute blast- Catra kinda regretted that she'd ever let such a person escape from her life at all. But it's not like her knees went weak around them or her heart fluttered or any dumb shit like that. It was just...completely comfortable. They had a great time together just goofing off, shooting the shit, and Adora was like her favorite person to mess with. It was their normal. Anyone with eyes could see that.

"So lovely to have you home for the holidays, dear!" Garnet called out sweetly as she fled the kitchen, not even having the decency to hide her boisterous chuckles.

I'll be in my room, text me when you're done. Catra quickly typed out, then flopped back on her bed. Being home with family was equal parts refreshing and exhausting. They were sure to have fun tonight, even if inevitably both Linda and Garnet would be snoring on the couch before 10:30, but it was kind of a dumb holiday to begin with. It was just a bunch of waiting around. And was staying up until midnight really that much of an accomplishment?

Catra heard the bathroom door open and sort of tensed. She thought about popping her head out to catch the dummy by surprise, but knowing her luck Adora would be just in a towel or something. Nothing she hadn't seen before back at the apartment, they all shared one bathroom and a hallway after all, but the thought just sort of...stuck with her this time. Best to just wait in here.

The return text didn't take nearly as long as she might have expected. Catra sighed, fortified herself for another night of family fun and wandered out into the hallway to wait for her guest. Felt like something she should do.

Barely fifteen seconds later, Adora came out of the spare bedroom. Catra's jaw dropped.

"Oh. Um, fuck." Adora stammered, crossing their arms over their chest in embarrassment, their cheeks tinged with a rosy pink. Idly Catra noticed that the blush seemed to go all the way down their neck. "I dressed up. Why did I dress up? That was dumb; it's not like we're going out, out."

"No! Uh, here, just wait a minute." Catra tore her eyes away from Adora's look, the white blouse with still modest but low neckline, how they were wearing their hair down, something Catra rarely if ever saw, and hurried back into her bedroom to reassess and adjust as necessary. She wasn't panicked per se; that would be a ridiculous reaction to this non-situation. But most of her really good clothes were at her apartment, because duh, of course they would be. And while Catra was sure the others in the house would probably be dressed in pjs, she didn't want Adora to feel out of place tonight.

No time to really think or plan, Catra quickly swapped out her t-shirt for a light blue collared shirt (leaving the top two buttons undone, of course) and a slate gray blazer that she miraculously had hanging in her closet here. Why the hell hadn't she brought this thing with her to school; she looked damn good in it. Especially since with all the rush, Catra's hair was looking even better than usual, all tousled and loose. Hah, Adora wasn't going to be the *only* insanely hot one here tonight. Errr. What?

Shaking her head clear, Catra eased back into the hallway, and promptly froze. Again. Annoying.

"Oh. Wow. Wow, you. You didn't." Adora was biting their bottom lip so hard that Catra could see how it was turning white from the

pressure. That might be a sign that they were standing too close to one another. With a long, shaky exhale, they eventually murmured, "You didn't have to go through all that trouble to change. For me."

"N-no trouble." Catra swallowed, tucking her hands into her jeans pockets. The dumb things kinda wanted to reach out and dunno, like touch Adora's arm or something equally as weird and uncalled for? Catra didn't understand it or wanna chance it. "It's just some clothes"…

Adora looked away at that, their expression unreadable, and Catra found herself quickly sputtering out, "But uh, yknow. You look the way you look."

"I look the way I look?" Adora replied with a quizzical lilt, almost bashful, but it had the teasing edge to it that was all part of what was normal for them.

"Yeah." Catra just managed to say, feeling supremely awkward with herself at this moment. She fidgeted with the cuff of her jacket for a moment, pulling at the length. Ah, right, the sleeves were a little too short for her. That's why it hadn't made the cut to come to school too. Aware that several seconds had gone by and Adora was still looking at her like that, Catra sort of mumbled, "It's good. With the skirt and all."

"Thanks. They're actually pants." Adora said slowly, but warmly, then pulled on the edge of their bottoms, demonstrating that the black, flowing material indeed had two separate legs. "Palazzo pants, Glimmer calls them. And hey! They've got pockets!"

"Pockets are good." Catra nodded, reflexively smiling at the dummy as they proudly showed off all the ins and outs of their garment, practically twirling about the hallway. Who gave them the right to be so. "Do you wanna head downstairs?

"Yup! Let's ring in the new year!"

They trickled into the living room, following the sounds of happy chatter over jazzy swing music. Linda had the record player going, there was a fire blazing in the hearth, and even though the young adults were still a few months (Adora mere days) short from it being legal, six champagne flutes were lined up next to the buffet of tiny foods they would spend the whole night snacking on.

"Well aren't you two striking! So handsome and sharp, the both of you."

Catra gave a half-shrug and Adora made a tittering laugh, their head bowed low so that their long, blonde hair covered the worst of their blush. Catra's fingers twitched; she kinda wanted to push it back for them. Okay, what the *fuck* was up with her tonight?

"Between you two and Scorp and Fuma, I feel like I'm about to get kicked out of my own house for some exclusive, fancy pants event." Scorpia's mom continued, winking at her wife. They were in matching flannel pajamas, but their daughter and her girlfriend were in complementary sequined dresses, Scorpia's black and Perfuma's a pale gold, the both of them totally decked out for a night in the living room. The spouses shared a knowing look, one that seemed to comment on the pageantry of youth.

Catra didn't have much to say to that, so merely rolled her eyes and went to fill her plate. Adora followed suit and the night quickly found its rhythm- jazzy music, good conversation, some light reminiscing, and plenty of laughs. It was pretty damn great, even if it was hands off the bubbly until midnight actually struck.

"Countdown is just a minute away!" Scorpia announced to the room. She and Perfuma had been locked in an embrace for the last ten minutes (well, some form of cuddle all damn night), their shared look blank and blissful in the last little bit left of the current year. Catra couldn't watch any more and just sort of glanced Adora's way, somewhat startled to see they were already looking at her.

“Y ou wanna?” Catra vaguely gestured towards the smaller of the two couches in the room and sort of half-nodded towards the TV. Watching the ball drop was kind of lame, but tradition was tradition sometimes.

“Okay , yeah.” Adora breathed out, following Catra to the loveseat. There was enough space for them to both sit comfortably, but the outside of Adora’s leg was just brushing Catra’ s own. It was all tingly, that minute bit of contact. Well then.

10.

Time seemed to slow in those last remaining seconds of the year. Dimly, Catra heard the countdown being called over the TV. Out of the corner of her eye, she saw Scorpia and Perfuma, wrapped up in a tight hug, Fuma smiling openly at something Scorpia had just whispered in her ear, the two clearly lost in their own little world. Garnet and Linda were just barely hanging in there, snuggled up under a giant throw on the couch together. And Adora…

7..

Adora was looking at her. Catra was looking right back, motionless, save for how her heart beat so rapidly in her chest. She faintly heard Garnet’s voice in the back of her mind, teasing her about a midnight kiss, and in this moment, it was hard to shake off. Because it sort of felt like…

4..

3.

2.

“Happy New Y ear, Catra.” Adora whispered, a second and a half after the clock turned to midnight and cheers broke out all over the broadcast on TV. Fireworks were sounding all through the

neighborhood, but Catra was entirely tuned into Adora's mouth. Er, words.

"Happy New Y ear."Catra' s voice was weak, lips barely moving as she parroted the sentiment back.

It was a little challenging after to shake of f the moment with Adora, if that's what it even was, but once Scorpia and Perfuma stopped locking lips and the room all wished one another a Happy New Year, the older folk called it for the night. The bottle of champagne was left for another time, Linda asserting that if she were to have imbibed, it should have been hours ago to avoid any chance of heartburn while trying to sleep. Scorp and Fuma were quick to bed as well, though Catra thought the mutual yawns were a little exaggerated. Best not to think about it too much.

A "Y ou tired?"Not really ."was all it took for Adora and Catra to return to their Switch game. Except, since the living room was so lovely and warm from the fire that had been burning all night in the large fireplace, not to mention the TVdown here was so much bigger than the one in her room, Catra brought down her dock and the pair returned to the loveseat they had been sitting on since a little before midnight. Maybe they didnt *have* to sit there, but…

"Use a godsbeard, dummy ."Catra warned, watching Adora pick through their available skills and completely ignore that they were down to only seven health. Adora gave a cute little oh!of surprise and quickly healed up. Catra totally didnt smile at the noise, nope.

A few more turns passed, the pair comfortable in each other's company. They were doing pretty well this time around, might even pull it off and finally beat the damn thing. Catra found herself watching Adora as they played, how their brows furrowed together as they contemplated their next move, how carefully they examined each new piece of gear even when it was only a few points of difference, and the little sparks of pure delight when they would crit and completely slaughter an enemy. Damn. Gaming with them

was. Hopefully Adora would want to keep doing this in the future as much as their schedules allowed. Catra didn't really want to let it go.

"Are you having an okay time?" Catra murmured, licking her lips. Adora *seemed* perfectly okay, barring dinner last night when they had obviously been caught in a tangle of weeds in their brain, but she wanted to be certain. It was just them down here, so the Adora could be totally honest. They'd just take it from there, whatever the answer was.

"Yeah, Cat, I really am." Adora paused their turn, shopping in the marketplace completely secondary to the question that had been asked of them. "Garnet and Linda are just so welcoming, it's hard not to!"

"Yeah, don't I know it." Catra chuckled, a warm little glow sparking in the center of her chest. She was pleased to hear that Adora liked them so much, even if like they said, it would be hard not to. They really were just good, good people. "Glad they aren't too much for ya. Garnet in particular can be a handful."

"Oh? I mean, I have practice multiple times a week with her daughter, so I'm kinda used to the noise. We also live with her, Cat." Adora winked, obviously thinking themselves so clever.

"No. I mean, yeah, shouting *is* their base level; Linda's really no better but she's been on her best behavior this visit. But that's not quite where I was going." Catra was actually only about 30% sure where she was going, but every impulse in her peabrain was telling her to keep heading that way. "She uh, likes to tease. I'm sure you've gathered that."

Adora nodded, brows furrowed, but otherwise let Catra speak. Stutter was closer to reality.

"Garnet's been particularly relentless about tonight. Exceedingly. Annoyingly." A creeping flush flickered along Catra's cheeks. Her tongue felt too thick for her mouth, spit was kind of gathering at the

back of her throat, but she was having trouble swallowing too. The human body could be so gross and irritating. "Kept hounding me about"…

"What?" Adora's voice was quiet, somehow even *more* fixated on her. It was truthfully hella unnerving, but Catra also kind of liked that they would ignore the game they'd been obsessed with recently just to listen to what she had to ramble about. Adora had always been the type to listen. It was Catra that had to invest some points in that branch of her skill tree.

Like she was a Sim, someone else had obviously taken control of Catra's actions. That was the only explanation for why she heard in what sounded like her own voice, "She sort of thought that you and I might well, um. Kiss at midnight"?

The last few words were squeaked out in a rush, tumbling over top of one another so much that (in addition to her general complete freaking out) Catra was nervous. Because what if Adora asked her to *repeat them*? She swore up and down that even three weeks ago, this would have just been something that they would laugh off together and completely ignore. But tonight, in the young hours of a brand new year, it just felt...different. They felt different, but it wasn't in a bad way? Catra thought, at least. So much hung on how Adora would react now. Fuck, why weren't they talking yet?

Adora was quiet and quiet for far longer than Catra's dumb self could handle. What was she thinking, admitting that? It was such a weird, weird thing to say to a friend. Catra was already losing hope for this year, because apparently she lost any and all good sense-...

"... I would have let you." Adora's voice was more tremble than anything else, so quiet that Catra almost wasn't able to hear it over the heroic background music of the video game.

"Huh"?

"If you had tried to k-kiss me at midnight, I would have let you." Adora repeated, somewhat stronger the second time.

"Oh." Catra's head went from swimming, a waterfall of cascading thoughts, jumbling over one another to take the spotlight and gain her sole attention to. Nothing. It was a clear slate. Entirely empty. Adora had struck her completely.

A swallow, and then in a quaking whisper, the question was posed. "Do you want to?"

"*Yes*." There was no hesitation, no pause, though Catra was somewhat relieved to hear the nerves in Adora's voice as clearly as they rang in her own. They were both equally adrift in this moment, just following...something. A nebulous feeling that craved solidity.

Another countdown began in Catra's head as she slowly turned to face the person seated next to her.

10.

It was just as earlier in the night, that *feeling*, that almost tangible tension between them sprung up immediately.

8.

Adora was serious, right? They weren't about to yell Psyche! and giggle that stupid little laugh that maybe did make Catra's heart flutter a little, at least when it caught her off guard.

7.

No? Because they had also turned Catra's way, their eyes just as wide as Catra was certain her own were. Adora set down their controller, never once breaking eye contact. Catra followed suit. If they were really going to do this, then she wasn't going to be holding a set of Joycons like a total *nerd.*

6.

Catra hadnt ever considered this, not seriously. Sure the *thought* had maybe crossed her mind once or twice, but it was always quickly dismissed. Adora was her friend.

4.

Friends kiss too.

2.

Right?

…

As she brushed against Adora’s soft lips- chaste, uncertain, startlingly and blissfully lucid thoughts came to Catra, as welcome as the small, eager noises that could have come from either one of them. Both of them was more likely.

They were never just friends.

It had always been them.

Happy new year.

Chapter End Notes

... Have I had Friends Kiss Too by Danny and Alex in my head for days now? You betcha. But we all knew they were never going to end up as just friends, Catra just had to stop swimming in that ol' river of De-nile. De-nial? Whatever, y'all know the joke.

Ahem, anyway. That's a wrap for this one! I had so, so much fun writing it and also loved hearing about people's gaming experiences in the comments. Keep 'em coming! Tell me your favorites, I want to hear.

Happy New Year, all! Hope it's fabulous. Catch some of you around Valentine's Day for certain, if the muse doesn't strike

sooner!

(PS- that CaH play? Girl's Best friend? Yeah. It was my fiancee's grandparents. Lol, never ever again!)
(PPS- Definitely about to go play For the King with Tara and my fiancee. We'll win one day, dammit!)

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!